ChatGPT is “one-fifth of Google.” Of what?

OpenAI says ChatGPT handles about one-fifth as many search-like queries as Google. It is OpenAI’s own claim.

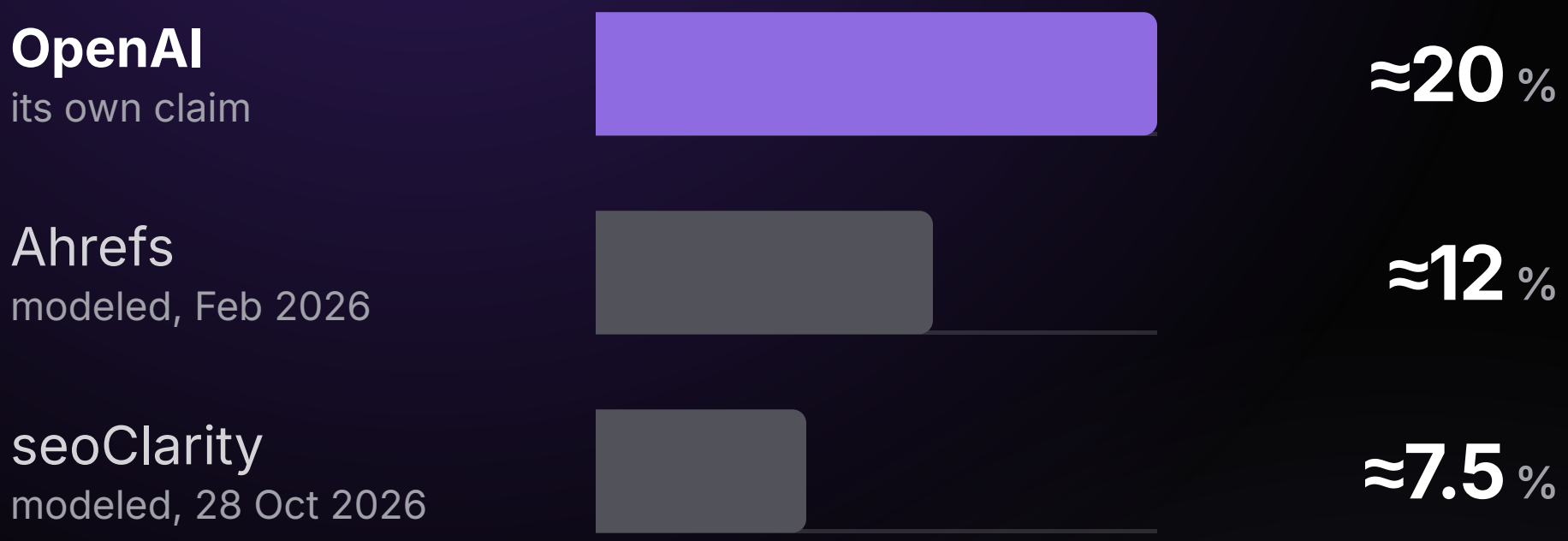
No Google total, no period and no regions were published. Three different measures follow.

Adam Fry, OpenAI, at an OpenAI event in New York; reported by 9to5Google and Big Technology, 3 Nov 2026.

THREE ESTIMATES

Same question, three answers

ChatGPT search-like queries as a share of Google’s.



Ahrefs counts only prompts that look like searches, using ChatGPT prompt data from July 2025. Counting every prompt, it gets 18%. seoClarity calls its figure a modeled comparison, not a measured share.

Ahrefs, Feb 2026. seoClarity, 28 Oct 2026. OpenAI via 9to5Google, 3 Nov 2026.

Queries are not visits

AHREFS · SEARCH VOLUME

12%

ChatGPT’s share of Google’s search volume, modeled

AHREFS · WEBSITE TRAFFIC

0.21%

ChatGPT’s share of traffic to 76,000 sites. Google: about 40%

Google sends about 190 times more visitors than ChatGPT. A question answered inside ChatGPT is not a click.

Ahrefs, Feb 2026, 76,000 websites. Same source, two different measures.

GOOGLE IS NOT SHRINKING

A fifth of a growing number is not a loss

ALPHABET · Q3 2026 · 28 OCT

Search and other revenue grew 12% year over year

SUNDAR PICHAI · Q3 2026 CALL

Year-over-year query growth was the highest in five years

ADAM FRY, OPENAI · SELF-REPORTED

ChatGPT went from 1 billion to 1.2 billion weekly users in two months

Both can be true: ChatGPT is large and growing, and Google’s own volume is also growing. The last line is my read.

Alphabet Q3 2026 results and call, 28 Oct 2026. OpenAI figures are self-reported; OpenAI is private.

What you can and cannot say

SAFE

OpenAI says ChatGPT handles roughly one-fifth as many search-like queries as Google. It has not disclosed the Google baseline, period or regions.

NOT SAFE

“ChatGPT has 20% of Google’s market share.”
“ChatGPT sends 20% as much traffic as Google.”
“Google lost 20% to ChatGPT.”

OpenAI counts a search each time a prompt makes ChatGPT search the web. That is not the same unit as a query on Google.

9to5Google, 3 Nov 2026; Big Technology, 3 Nov 2026.

WHAT I WOULD DO

This week, three checks

1

Check you are not blocking OAI-SearchBot

OpenAI says it is the bot behind ChatGPT search answers. GPTBot is separate, for training.

2

Ask your 10 buyer questions in ChatGPT

Write down who is cited and which sources it shows. Do it again next month.

3

Add “ChatGPT or another AI” to “how did you find us?”

It is the cheapest way to see what the last click hides.

Sources: OpenAI crawler documentation (read 4 Nov 2026). Links to every source in the first comment.